



*Jellyfish bell
full of water*

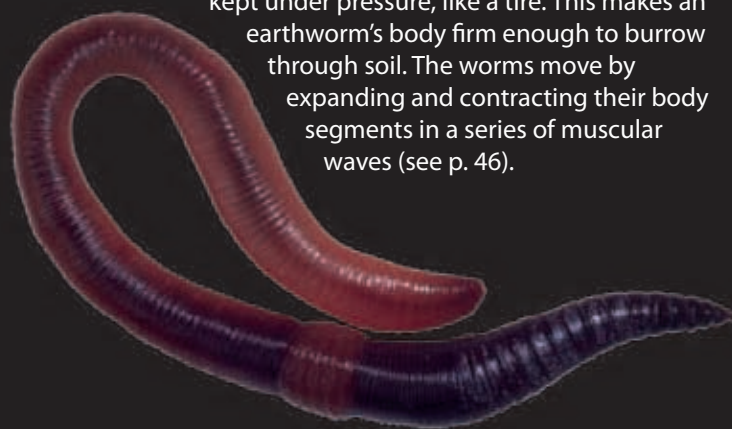
Living together

This sea fan is not just one animal, but a branching colony containing thousands of tiny coral animals called polyps. Each polyp has a soft body, which sits in a bright red case. The cases are cemented together, forming the branches of the fan. Sea fan polyps have flexible cases, but reef-building corals have much harder ones made from calcium carbonate—the same mineral found in chalk.



Pumped up

Earthworms have soft bodies that are divided into fluid-filled segments, and each one is kept under pressure, like a tire. This makes an earthworm's body firm enough to burrow through soil. The worms move by expanding and contracting their body segments in a series of muscular waves (see p. 46).



A soft start

Many animals start life with soft bodies, which become tougher as they grow up. These young scorpions, riding on their mother's back, have a soft outer "skin" or body case. Each time they shed their skin, or molt, a thicker and harder skin develops in its place.



Inside a sea anemone

Sea anemones are related to jellyfish and corals, and their bodies share the same plan, with a ring of stinging tentacles surrounding a central mouth. The mouth opens into a hollow space where the anemone digests its food. A sucker usually fastens the anemone to rocks, although some anemones have a rounded base that anchors them in sand.

